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YES YMP-35
 Snazzy looks, jazzy sound

Features Pretty, pretty

Perhaps the most traditional looking (as in what a PMP *should* look like) players of this lot are the Transcend T.sonic 610 and the Philips SA3125, albeit in vastly different threads—the former favouring a smooth finish, off-white, while the latter is decked in a smudge-prone and glossy piano black. The T.sonic 630 was heralded as the successor to the long-running 610; it is much smaller, but it's not as attractive. The "Lil Monsta"—as it's called—from Sandisk (the Sansa c240) looks unassuming, though build quality is top class. The unique-looking YMP-35 makes another appearance here in 1 GB guise, while the YES YMP-30 is a solidly built, but plain-looking device.

Both the Transcends have issues with navigation buttons, while the 5-way menu button on the T.sonic 610 is a major pain. To use the small, hard-to-press buttons on the 630 is an ergonomic nightmare! The Mitashi MPS 1002 has a good array of well-laid-out buttons. The Philips SA3125 also has very hard-to-press, tiny buttons that weren't fun to play around with.

Gimme More...

The Transcend T.sonic comes with a transparent plastic case and an armband. A neck strap is an accessory in common with both the Transcend players. This makes it an out-of-the-box companion for workouts. With MicroSD expansion, FM support, and a clear and crisp screen, the Sansa c240 is loaded on the features front. In fact, the screen is one of the highlights on the c240—it's also the best priced in its category.

Once again, all the players in this category don't miss a trick with FM radio support. The Eurone Upro PMP-MM5 also includes a 3.2 megapixel camera—the only PMP bold enough to take this convergent move. The display, however, could have been a bit better. Incidentally, the camera is very ordinary and performs inadequately as compared to the 3.2 megapixel camera on the Nokia N73 phone.

On a slightly negative note, the Upro PMP-

MM5s metal body got quite hot while charging via USB, though this wasn't so apparent while charging using the AC adapter. We tried another USB port only to face the same problem.

Performance

The Philips SA3125 and the Transcend T.sonic 630 were the barely legal boys—just brushing the upper limits of the category. The former offers decent sound, but lacks decent volume levels on the Bose earplugs (due to driving issues). To Philips' credit, the bundled earphones are pretty good.

The T.sonic 630 was followed by its (Rs 500 cheaper) sibling, the T.sonic 610. We feel the internals of these players including the codecs used are identical. There is one issue, however: the default earphones on the 610 are much better than the ones supplied with the 630; these distort quite a bit. Sound quality with the Bose in both cases is nearly identical.

The YES YMP-30 also performed commendably, stealing Transcend's thunder with sheer audio quality. The Mitashi MPS-1002 also did quite well, though we noticed a slight lack in bass depth, particularly in U2's *With or Without You*.

If you're looking at good music quality and features above everything else, the simple and compact "Lil Monsta" (a.k.a. the c240 from Sandisk) makes a very good deal—good quality with the bundled earphones, but didn't perform well on the Bose reference earplugs. Especially noticeable was the sharp, clear treble. Of course, the YMP-30 (YES) and the MPS-1002 (Mitashi) provide a better overall sound experience. The attractive looking Eurone PMP-MM5 didn't do too well here—it wasn't driving the Bose earphones well enough, and didn't come bundled with a good set of earbuds itself.

Where Do I Go From Here?

For its combination of good build, a great set of features, and exemplary music experience we're giving Digit's Best Buy Gold award to Sandisk's "lil monsta"—the Sansa c240 (Rs 4,975). For a slightly lower set of features and a little drop in acoustic quality, you can pick up our Best Buy Silver winner—the Transcend T.sonic 610—for Rs 4,500. As attractive as the newer T.sonic 630 looks, we suggest you go with the older, more proven model—although there's a negligible difference, the 610 sounds better on its bundled earbuds, and the accessory list is a little better.

If you want a little better sound quality, opt for the loud-speaker-bearing Mitashi MPS-1002 or the simple-looking rugged YES YMP-30.

These sound slightly better than the Sansa c240 and the T.sonic 610, but miss out on quite a few features like expansion, a customisable equaliser (important for music buffs), and intra-track repeat.

Many of the PMPs come bundled with average earphones. Make sure to test players with a standard set as well

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Sandisk Sansa c240
 A real lil monsta!